



Norwegian Escape — Thanksgiving Caribbean

7 Nights from Port Canaveral · November 20 – 27, 2026

Ship: Norwegian Escape · **Sailing from:** Port Canaveral, FL · **Cabin:** _____ **Host:** Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co. ·

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A condensed Voyage Pack from [In the Wake](#) — the essentials in three pages. The full pack covers cabins, packing, budget, ship orientation, Caribbean weather strategy, ports in depth, NCL's quirks, and Thanksgiving aboard.

Day by day

#	Day	Port	Hours ashore	Tender	The one thing
1	Fri Nov 20	Port Canaveral — embarkation	board 11:30 AM – 3:30 PM; depart 4–5 PM	—	All-aboard 3:30 PM. Studio meet-and-greet Day 1 in the Studio Lounge.
2	Sat Nov 21	Cruising at sea	—	—	Settling-in day. Sunrise coffee in the Observation Lounge. Book specialty dining + Great Tides Waterpark slot.
3	Sun Nov 22	Puerto Plata (Amber Cove), DR	8:00 AM – 5:00 PM	—	Damajagua Waterfalls (\$50–95) or stay at Amber Cove pools/beach (free).
4	Mon Nov 23	St. Thomas, USVI	10:00 AM – 6:00 PM	—	Magens Bay (\$17 r/t taxi + \$5 entry) or ferry to St. John's Trunk Bay (~\$16 r/t).
5	Tue Nov 24	Tortola, BVI	8:00 AM – 5:00 PM	—	Cane Garden Bay (~\$30 r/t taxi) or The Baths on Virgin Gorda (\$150–200 all-in).
6	Wed Nov 25	Cruising at sea	—	—	Second sea day. Port talk for Great Stirrup Cay. Last good cell day before the cay's signal dark zone.
7	Thu Nov 26	Great Stirrup Cay (NCL) + THANKSGIVING aboard	9:00 AM – 5:00 PM cay	yes	Cay BBQ + waterpark by day; Thanksgiving dinner 5:30 PM Manhattan Room. Passport not required for Bahamian private cay , but required for the rest of the itinerary.
8	Fri Nov 27	Port Canaveral — debarkation	off by 10:00 AM	—	Black Friday — MCO traffic spikes by afternoon. Self-disembark starts ~7 AM.

The Caribbean packing rule is layers-light. Quick-dry shirts, swimsuit rotation, light rain shell, water shoes for Damajagua. Skip heavy clothes — late-November Caribbean is 78–86°F daytime.

Thanksgiving Day placement varies by sailing. Some Friday-to-Friday weeks put the cay on Wednesday and Thanksgiving fully at sea. **Verify your day order in the NCL app** when published.

Currency aboard: USD. **Auto-gratuity:** \$20/day per person standard (\$25/day Suites/Haven); verify if pre-paid in your group rate.

Decide before you board. Run the [drink-calculator](#) on your real drinking pattern, the [budget-calculator](#) for the total-fare picture, and the [tipping-calculator](#) for auto-grats + cash tips — mid-sail upgrades cost more per day and give you fewer days of usage.

Getting to the ship — and getting home

Arrival: Thursday recommended, Friday required

Thursday Nov 19 — fly into MCO. Same-day flights to a 3:30 PM Friday all-aboard during **Thanksgiving week — the busiest US travel week of the year** are risky. Thursday-night hotel in Cocoa Beach (15 min from port) or Orlando/MCO area (45 min from port).

If you can absorb the extra night, Wednesday Nov 18 arrival gives the largest weather + delay buffer.

Friday — embarkation.

- **Terminal: Port Canaveral, Cruise Terminal 10** (verify in NCL app 14 days before).
- **MCO → Port Canaveral:** Uber/Lyft 45–60 min, \$60–80. Shared cruise shuttle ~\$30/person, slower.
- **If driving:** Port Canaveral garage ~\$17–22/day (significantly cheaper than PortMiami).
- **Embark window:** 11:30 AM – 3:30 PM. **All-aboard 3:30 PM.** Ship departs ~4:00–5:00 PM.
- **NCL app online check-in** before arrival — completes faster than paper.

Day 8 debark and the trip home

- **The night before** (Thanksgiving evening): bags in the hall with color-coded tag by ~11 PM.
- **6:30 AM:** Customs clearance.
- **7:00 – 9:30 AM:** Walk-off in waves; self-disembark starts ~7 AM.
- **10:00 AM (latest):** All passengers off.

Black Friday traffic timing. Nov 27 is Black Friday — Florida highway traffic is light early morning but spikes by mid-afternoon. Build the buffer in. Cocoa Beach outlets see the worst of it.

Getting from Port Canaveral to MCO. Uber/Lyft \$60–80, 45–60 min. Cocoa Beach Shuttle (~\$30/person, advance booking) is the budget option.

Airport-arrival timing for MCO.

Flight	Leave Port Canaveral by
Domestic, after 4 PM	12:30 PM
International, after 6 PM	2:00 PM

MCO TSA on Black Friday afternoon runs heavy — give margin.

Killing 4–6 hours before an evening flight: Cocoa Beach pier (15 min, beach + lunch); Kennedy Space Center (20 min, \$75 entry, half-day minimum); Cocoa Beach outlets if Black Friday shopping is your thing.

Areas of interest during the cruise

On the ship — Escape spots worth knowing

- **The Observation Lounge** (Deck 15 forward) — wraparound glass; panoramic. Sunrise coffee here is the day's best 30 minutes; quiet at 6 AM.
- **Studio Lounge** — solo-cruiser social anchor. Free coffee, hosted hours, scheduled meet-and-greets. NCL hosts a Day 1 gathering.
- **The Aqua Park** — Aqua Racer (twin-tube racing slides), Free Fall slides, The Whip. All free.
- **The three-deck race track** (aft) — paid (~\$15/race); shorter lines first hour after opening.
- **Vibe Beach Club** — adults-only enclave, \$99/day or \$399/week. Quietest pool on the ship.
- **The Haven** — ship-within-a-ship suite enclave (if your cabin is in there).
- **Guy Harvey hull artwork** — Escape's marlin-and-billfish mural is the iconic pier photo.

Sea-day priorities (Day 2 and Day 6)

1. **Sunrise coffee in the Observation Lounge** — the trip's best 30 minutes.
2. **Book Great Tides Waterpark slot** — Thanksgiving sailings fill 60+ days pre-cruise; book Day 1 if not done.
3. **Specialty dining reservation** for the second half of the week.
4. **NCL app port talks** for Puerto Plata (Day 2) and Great Stirrup Cay (Day 6).
5. **Mandara Spa thermal-suite day pass** — sea-day intro rate.

Theme nights and the holiday calendar

NCL runs a lighter theme-night cadence than Royal. Watch for “**Norwegian's Night Out**” (the one optional slightly-dressier evening — not formal night; jacket not required) and the **White Hot Party** (white attire, deck party). The **Thanksgiving evening (Day 7)** is the dressier-than-usual night by tradition rather than NCL mandate — many cruisers dress slightly nicer for the holiday meal. **Smartest packing move:** one all-white outfit (works for White Hot + doubles as smart-casual) + one autumn-toned accessory (scarf, wrap, sequined top) for Thanksgiving. Specific nights confirm in the daily program once aboard.

Day 7 — Great Stirrup Cay + Thanksgiving aboard

Cay (9 AM – 5 PM):

- **Great Tides Waterpark** (opened Sept 2026) — Tidal Tower racing slides, Wandering River, Cliffside Cove platform-jumping, Splash Cay/Harbor family zone, 19 slides total. Reservation-based, paid add-on.
- **Free with fare:** Beach access (multiple zones), BBQ buffet lunch, Great Life Lagoon (28,000-sq-ft pool with swim-up bars), tram service from Welcome Plaza, lounge chairs/umbrellas (first-come).
- **Paid add-ons:** Flighthouse Zipline (~\$20), Underwater Snorkel Garden, Vibe Shore Club (\$79+, adults-only), cabanas (\$300–700+), Silver Cove (ultra-premium adults-only).

Thanksgiving dinner (5:30 – 9:00 PM):

- **The traditional feast** — roast turkey, stuffing, sweet potatoes, cranberry sauce, green bean casserole, pumpkin/pecan/apple pie — runs across the [Manhattan Room](#), Taste, and Savor. **No extra charge.**
- **Tina's group typically gathers at Manhattan Room 5:30 PM** — verify in her communications.
- **Specialty restaurants stay open with regular menus** if you'd rather have steak or French. Book 60+ days pre-cruise.
- **The shower-and-rest window** between 4 PM (back-aboard from cay) and 5:30 PM dinner is the unspoken rhythm.

Specialty dining picks

- [Cagney's Steakhouse](#) — NCL's standard steakhouse; reliably good.
- [Le Bistro](#) — French; the most romantic specialty room.
- [Teppanyaki](#) — Japanese hibachi; group-friendly.
- [Food Republic](#) — pan-Asian small plates; one of NCL's most distinctive specialty rooms.
- [Q Texas Smokehouse](#) — Texas BBQ.
- [La Cucina](#) — Italian.

Port-day picks (one each)

- **Puerto Plata (Amber Cove)** — Damajagua Waterfalls (27 cascades to climb + slide; \$50–95) is the iconic experience. If you want low-stress, Amber Cove's pools + beach + lunch is fine.
- **St. Thomas** — Magens Bay (one of the most-photographed beaches in the world, ~\$17 r/t taxi + \$5 entry) is the classic; ferry to St. John's Trunk Bay is the postcard upgrade.
- **Tortola** — Cane Garden Bay (~\$30 r/t) for the beach day; The Baths on Virgin Gorda (\$150–200 all-in) for the granite-boulder swim caves.
- **Great Stirrup Cay** — see Day 7 section above. Most cruisers do morning waterpark/Flighthouse + afternoon beach.

Photo spots worth knowing

- **Sailaway from the Pool Deck** — Cape Canaveral as the ship pulls away; sunset light on the Florida coast.
- **Observation Lounge sunrise** — panoramic windows; Eastern Caribbean dawn at sea.
- **Amber Cove from the upper decks** — green Dominican mountains behind the cruise port.
- **Magens Bay from Mountain Top** — the iconic St. Thomas harbor postcard.
- **The Baths on Virgin Gorda** — granite boulders, turquoise pools.
- **Great Stirrup Cay from the tender** — the marlin hull artwork in profile against Bahamian water.

Need an at-home emergency handoff card? Separate one-page doc available from [In the Wake](#). The full Voyage Pack is the unabridged companion document. Soli Deo Gloria.